“A Wreath of Tears” is a touching funeral tribute.

The writer, **Kobena Eyi Acquah** dedicated it to the pastor of a Methodist Church called Osofopon S.B Esamuah. The deceased was the president of the Methodist church of Ghana from 1979 to 1984.

Osofopon means a head pastor or reverend minister in Akan Language. The poet tells the noble nature of the senior minister. He also reveals some issues which arose during his funeral.

We will look at

- **the explanation of the poem**
- **themes**
- **structure**
- **literary devices**
- **questions and answers.**

But first, let’s read the poem.

A WREATH OF TEARS

Your funeral

was so quiet, and small -almost too small, it is said for a man of

your stature

you must

have preferred it that way -

having buried so many yourself and knowing as you did

how private grief must be how loss remains, at the end personal

we would have sent flowers but seeing how they had fallen

Callously into disrepute

and not wanting to offend

we did not

instead

from the garden of memory suddenly blooming as with first rains

we plucked, with care

a rose here, an ivy there, ferns, lilies chrysanthemums

and drop by tearful drop we wove

a wreath from our personal loss

we wear it

around our hearts, privately it will outlast any tombstone

And you would

Have preferred it that way.

Explanation of the Poem

Saying goodbye in a simple, private manner.

In most Ghanaian societies, people use a lot of money to organise funerals. Some go as far as taking huge amounts of loans to honour the dead. The poet expected a big funeral ceremony for a man with such great reputation but that was not the case.

You must have preferred it that way.

Since the poet knew about the humble personality of the reverend, he suspected it was how he wanted it. Because the reverend has led many burials, he is aware that grief is a private matter.

We would have sent flowers.

Another issue that arose was whether to send flowers or not.

The decision to send flowers brought about an unwanted misunderstanding. The poet is not happy about the fact that a petty issue of flowers could cause an argument. Funerals bring the loved ones of an individual together not separation.

Drop by tearful drop they wove

Instead of flowers, the people at the funeral create a special wreath using memories. They choose flowers like roses, ivy, ferns, lilies, and chrysanthemums. Each flower represents a different memory. What's powerful is that everyone contributes to this wreath, making it a group effort. The poet compares it to a lovely garden that grows from the tears and memories of the minister who has passed away.

A meaningful farewell

The wreath is not a physical object like a tombstone. Instead, it is a symbol of shared emotions that will last for a long time.

This personal wreath, worn around the hearts of loved ones, will last more than any tombstone.

It also says that the connections we have with people in our hearts are more important than physical things.

Conclusion

In a “wreath of tears”, the poet helps us see the beauty in a quiet and simple goodbye. The poem talks about the personal side of grief, and the lasting power of memories.

Sometimes, meaningful goodbyes don’t need big ceremonies.

Themes in the poem

1. The death of an individual affects those who are very close to him/her more than others who are not. So, grief is more for family and loved ones and less for the public.

2. Funerals should unite loved ones not cause disunity among family and friends. It is not a place for conflict over petty issues.

3. A meaningful farewell lives in the heart but not in the display of physical things. The tone is that of mourning for a deceased person and the pain associated with losing a loved one.

Form and Structure

The poet uses uneven lines in writing without any rhymes. The difficulty of the words used are intermediate. There is also the use of short lines at the beginning of each stanza.

Literary devices

Alliteration

- **We would have sent flowers**
- **We wear it**

Metaphor

From the garden of memory: The poet uses the garden to represent a collection of memories.

A rose here, an ivy there, rose lilies, chrysanthemums. The poet uses these different kinds of flowers to represent memories.

Imagery

And drop by tearful drop we wove: This line describes by appealing to our sense of touch and sight. It creates an image of pain and sorrow

Onomatopoeia

Suddenly blooming as with first rains: The poet uses the sound word, “blooming”, to show the opening of a flower.

Questions and Answers on the poem

1. Whose funeral is the poet talking about?

Answer: **Osofopon S.B. Esamuah**

2. What will outlast any tombstone?

Answer: **The wreath of tears**

3. What is the tone of the poem?

Answer: **Sorrowful/sad**

4. Mention some qualities of the departed soul.

Answer: **Humble and respectable**

5. Why was the funeral ceremony brief?

Answer: **The deceased might have liked it that way**

6. State three literary devices in the poem.

Answer: **Alliteration, imagery and metaphor.**

7. What major social issues did the poem raise?

Answer: **the nature and cost of funeral celebrations**

Answer: **Disagreements and conflicts which occur during funerals**

8. Why would they not send flowers to the funeral ?

Answer: **They did not want to offend anyone**

9. Comment on the mention of flowers.

Answer: **Flowers are delicate and beautiful. They show strong emotions even without using words.**

10. What is the meaning of, ” having buried so many yourself”?

Answer: **It means he has conducted many burial ceremonies.**

11.What had fallen Callously into disrepute?

Answer: **The flowers**